STATE SCAN

GOA: GRAND OPPOSITION ALLIANCE *PG 18*

W. BENGAL: MATUAS' MIGRANT BLUES *PG 20*



A GRAND STAGE The Maharishi Valmiki International Airport in Ayodhya; (right) PM Modi at the Ram temple for the Dhwajarohan ceremony, Nov. 25

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

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AYODHYA IN A NEW AVATAR

UP is making the Mandir city a model of development

By **Avaneesh Mishra**

ITS 2024 ELECTORAL LOSS AT AYODHYA, which dominates the Faizabad Lok Sabha constituency, was like a hit to the solar plexus for the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). It came within months of the Ram temple inauguration. Inside the party, it produced a deep rethink: how to reassert Ayodhya's political centrality? The soul-searching has yielded a new hybrid model. Call it reinforcing faith with hard, material development. The Yogi Adityanath government has gone about it with some urgency, treating the city not only as a pilgrimage centre but as the showcase of its infrastructure thrust.

On November 25, when Prime Minister Narendra Modi hoisted the *dharma dhwaja* on the 161-foot *shikhara*, that was meant to denote the original temple project coming to completion. But the larger political project is only entering its next phase. Ayodhya is now described as the benchmark of Uttar Pradesh's 'model city' plans on multiple fronts: town planning, energy, sanitation, medical facilities, green zones. The idea will be to present all this future-ready urbanity through vocabulary anchored in religious heritage.

THE SOLAR CITY

Take how the government has cast Ayodhya's new designation as a model solar city within the narrative of it as the Sun City. A 40 MW solar plant set up along the Saryu river already meets a quarter of the city's power demand. The 2031 Master Plan details a transition to near-total clean-energy reliance. Over 15,000 trees are being planted using